

Liang Chen Dr.

218, Building 188, Fellow Lane
The Australian National University, Acton ACT 2601
Email: liang.chen@anu.edu.au

SHORT BIO

Having completed my PhD at the Australian National University with a thesis on China's urbanisation and domestic migration, I have since broadened my research interests to China's engagements with the global South. Since 2017, I have taught anthropology and Chinese Studies at Sun Yat-sen University, the University of Botswana, and the Australian National University. My publications span science, technology, and society (STS), industrial relations, urbanisation, migration, and transnationalism in both global and local contexts.

EDUCATION

- PhD. Anthropology. The Australian National University, 2016
Dissertation: Getting by in Urban China: Sociality, Gender and Political Identity Among Migrant Petty Entrepreneurs.
Panel: Prof Andrew Kipnis, Prof Luigi Tomba, and Prof Philip Taylor
- M.A. Sociology. Peking University, 2009
Thesis: Labour Control and Cultural Practices in a Private Company in China.
Supervised by Prof Xiaoyang Zhu
- B. E. Chemical Engineering. Donghua University, 2003
Thesis title: Synthesis and Characterisation of Polyurethane Memory Plastic.

EMPLOYMENT

- 2026 Research Officer, Australian Centre on China in the World, The Australian National University (two research projects)
- 2024–2025 Visiting Fellow, Australian Centre on China in the World, The Australian National University
- 2021–2023 Lecturer, Chinese Studies Programme, College of Humanities, University of Botswana
- 2017–2021 Research Associate, Centre for Migration and Ethnic Studies, Sun Yat-sen University

PUBLICATIONS

My publications are organised around three interconnected themes, each bringing together local ethnographic insights with broader global processes in the Chinese, African, and Australian contexts.

Migration, Informal Economy, and Urbanisation in Post-Socialist China

- 2026 Chen, Liang. "Rural Migrants in the Informal Economy of Urbanising China: Violence and Whitewashed Government Legitimacy." *China Perspectives*, no. 144 (2026): 77–86.
- 2017 Liang Chen, Potentialities(*shi*) for Territory: Life and Spatial Strategies of Migrants. *Guangxi Journal of Nationalities*. vol. 40 (1). p. 27-35.
- Translation work*
- 2021 Andrew Kipnis, *From Village to City: Social Transformation in a Chinese County Seat*. Translated by Liang Chen and M. Bai. Taipei: Taiwan National University Press.
- 2021 Daming Zhou, *Revisiting China's Rural Urbanisation: A Pearl River Delta Region Perspective*. Translated by Liang Chen. London: Routledge.

Chinese and Africans on the Move: Transnationalism, Technology, and Race

- 2026 Liang Chen. Does Chinese Capital Help Industrial Development in the Third World? Strained Technology Transfer Between Chinese and Ethiopians. *China Review*. Accepted. Forthcoming August 2026.
- 2025 Chen, Liang. Chinese Employers in Botswana and Their Impact on Local Workers. *Melbourne Asian Review*, 22. DOI: 10.37839/MAR2652-550X22.11. Available at:

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<https://www.melbournesiareview.edu.au/chinese-employers-in-botswana-and-their-impact-on-local-workers/>.

- 2024 Liang Chen and Mariame Traore. Governing the Strangers: African Communities in Guangzhou. *The China Story*. 10 December. Available at: <https://www.thechinastory.org/governing-strangers-african-communities-in-guangzhou/>
- 2021 Denghua Zhang and Liang Chen. Perceptions and Frustrations: Chinese Companies in the Global South. *The China Story*. 10 May. Available at: <https://www.thechinastory.org/perceptions-and-frustrations-chinese-companies-in-the-global-south/>
- 2020 Yanhua Hu & Liang Chen. A Tripod Knowledge: The Cultural Ecology of Growing GM Crops in Australian Farmland. *Journal of Southwest University for Nationalities (Humanities and Social Science)*. 2020(4). p. 40-49.

Globalization in Africa: University Reform, Heritage, and Infrastructure-led Changes

- 2024 Liang Chen & Tshepho Mosweu. Indigenising Museum Practises through Traditions: Age Group and Youth Troupe in Botswana. *Heritage (Yichan)*. 2024 (9), 53-71.
- 2023 Liang Chen & Naijing Liu. The “Transformation” Crisis of African Public Universities under the Pandemic: A Case Study of the Strike at the University of Botswana. In Haifang Liu (ed.), *Opportunities in Crisis: Africa in Times of Unprecedented Changes (Annual Review of African Studies in China)*. Beijing: The Commercial Press: 197-217.

Other

- 2004 Qing Shen, Di Mu, Li-Wei Yu, Liang Chen. A simplified approach for evaluation of the polarity parameters for polymer using the K coefficient of the Mark-Houwink-Sakurada equation. *Journal of Colloid and Interface Science* vol. 275: 30-34

Book Chapters

- 2026 Liang Chen. The Rise and Transformation of the Aksumite Civilization (Chapter 6); Ethiopia and the Horn of Africa (8th–15th Centuries) (Chapter 17). In Anshan Li (ed.), *General History of Africa*. Forthcoming.
- 2024 Liang Chen. Inherit Culture from the Margins: A Rural Youth Theatre Troupe in Botswana. In Haifang Liu (ed.), *Youth Development and China-Africa Cooperation*. Beijing: The Commercial Press: 81-98.
- 2022 Liang Chen. A National Megaproject, a Diplomatic Megagift, or Mega-neglect of the Local? In Biljana Ćirić (ed.), *As You Go...Roads Towards Your Feet, Towards the New Future*. Rockbund Art Museum and Mousse Publishing: 186-197.

Book Reviews

- 2024 Liang Chen. Review of Christina Seyfried, *African Bargaining Power with China: Foreign Investment and Rising Influence*. *The China Journal*, No. 92, July. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1086/730609>
- 2024 Naijing Liu & Liang Chen. Review of Nicolas Evans, *Words of Wonder: Endangered Languages and What They Tell Us*. *Shanghai Review of Books*. 24 September. Available at: https://m.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_28821434.
- 2021 Liang Chen. Review of Miriam Derissen, *Tales of Hope, Tastes of Bitterness: Chinese Road Builders in Ethiopia*. *Northeast African Studies*, Vol. 21, No. 1: 151–155.
- 2019 Liang Chen. Review of Borge Bakken, *Crime and the Chinese Dream*. *Asian Journal of Criminology*. Vol. 14: 259-260. DOI 10.1007/s11417-019-09286-z
- 2019 Liang Chen. Where Do Men Shed Their Tears? Sentiments in Rural-Urban Mobility. Review of Susanne Yuk-Ping Choi and Yinni Peng, *Masculine Compromise*. *Shanghai Review of Books*. 20 November. Available at: https://www.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_4970912.

Media Engagement

I write about topics that are relevant to both African and Chinese, such as pandemic, migration, and politics, in reputable English and Chinese media.

- 2021 Liang Chen. The Amhara People and Ethiopianism. *East Africa Lookout (dongfei liaowang)*. 26 August. Available at: <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/j8fKqMj7T9nw7orjwYbxUg>
- 2020 Liang Chen. Beating Around the Bush: Some Reflections on the Crisis of “Imported Cases” of Africans in Guangzhou. *As You Go Journal*. 15 June. Available at:

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- <http://wscsd.com/index.php/wscsd-curatorial-inquiries/as-you-go-journal/beating-around-the-bush/>
- 2020 Liang Chen. Malaria, Dams, AIDS and Coronavirus Pneumonia: Dr Tedros Adhanom's Brokering Public Health Politics. *Initium Media*. 11 March. Available at: <https://theinitium.com/article/20200311-opinion-tedros-adhanom-who-africa/>
- 2019 Liang Chen. Afar (Ethiopia) Travel Logs. *The Paper (peng pai)*. 15 November. Available at: https://www.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_4956181.
- 2019 Liang Chen. What It Means for Ethnic Politics When PM Abiy Ahamed Won Nobel Peace Prize. *Initium Media* 14 October. Available at: <https://theinitium.com/article/20190914-opinion-abiy/>
- 2017 Liang Chen, *Dark was the Night Market*, The World of Chinese: Vol. 1: Taobao Town, Page 46–9. Available at: <https://www.theworldofchinese.com/2017/02/dark-was-the-night-market/>

Funding and Grants

- 2025 Australian Centre on China in the World (CIW) Travel Grant. Amount Awarded: AUD 3,000.
- 2022-4 Transnational Chinese in Botswana: Migration, Businesses, and Education
Funded by French Institute of South Africa (IFAS). Amount Awarded: €1,000(AUD 1,650)
- 2019-2021 Research project “As You Go...roads under your feet, towards the new future.” (Researcher), funded by Rockbund Art Museum (Shanghai). Amount Awarded: CNY 6,500 (AUD 1,400)
- 2018-2020 Urbanisation of the Pastoralist Afar in Ethiopia and Djibouti (PI).
In this project I investigated the social and religious transformations of the pastoralist Afar triggered by irrigation scheme, infrastructure, and urbanisation.
Grant No: 18WKPY48. Funded by “Perspective Young Scholar” Program at Sun Yat-sen University. Amount Awarded: CNY 25,000(AUD 5,300). Period of Grant Award: 2018-2020.
- 2017-2020 Transcontinental Assemblage: Africans in Guangzhou (PI)
This project aims to investigate how Africans socialise among themselves and with Chinese when doing business in Guangzhou. I use the notion “assemblage” to refer to the indeterminate, fluid boundaries among Africans and Chinese.
Grant No: 2017-GMG-028. Funded by Research Program of State Ethnic Affairs Commission of China. Total Amount Awarded: CNY30,000(AUD 6,500). Period of Grant Award: 2017-2020.
- 2017-2020 Translation of *Revisiting China's Rural Urbanisation: A Pearl River Delta Region Perspective* by Zhou, Daming.
The book explores how the rural urbanisation in Southern China has unleashed many potentials since the Reform and Opening Up.
Grant No: 17WSH004. Funded by Translation Project of the Chinese Humanities and Social Sciences of National Social Science Fund of China. Total Amount Awarded: CNY200,000(AUD43,000). Period of Grant Award: 2017-2020.
- 2009-2016 Urbanisation and Migrant entrepreneurs. PhD Project, ANU.
I explored the social imaginaries, survival tactics, and everyday struggle and performances of migrants. The results of this research go into my PhD dissertation *Getting by in Urban China: Sociality, Gender and Political Identity Among Migrant Petty Entrepreneurs*.
In this project, I received full tuition scholarship and full stipend from The Australian Research Council (ARC). Grant No: DP0984510. Project Title: “The making of urban citizens: social inclusion and division in China's new urban areas”. Co-PI: Prof Andrew Kipnis and Dr Luigi Tomba. Period of Grant Award: 2009-2012.
- 2006 Urban Restructuring and Urban villages in Shenzhen, China
I examined the public goods provision in a restructuring urban village and the consumption, leisure, and social imaginaries of migrant workers in it. I received a grant of CNY 5,000 from Peking University Research Grants.

TEACHING AND SUPERVISION

As Lecturer/tutor of Chinese Studies

- 2021-2023 I have taught intensively (3 courses per semester on average) at Chinese Studies Programme at University of Botswana as a lecturer. The courses included Political Economy of Contemporary China, Chinese Speaking Societies in the World, Hot Topics in China, Africa's Relation with China.

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Content courses

2012-2025 Tutored and lectured 8 Mandarin language courses at the Australian National University

As Lecturer in Anthropology

2019-2021 Sun Yat-sen University, School of Anthropology and Sociology, Lecturer
Mooc course Linguistic Anthropology (2020)
SA2079 Developmental Anthropology (2019)
2018 School of Government, Peking University, Guest Lecturer
Course title: Developments in China. Delivered to 50 government officials from BRI countries

Student Supervision

2018-2021 School of Anthropology and Sociology of Sun Yat-sen University
Student: Ms Mariame Traore. Thesis title: Building Cross-Continental Business Infrastructure: The Case of the Guinean Community in China. Submitted in 2022.
Student: Ms Chang Lei. Thesis title: Trans-border Marketplace: Supply Chain, Identity, and Everyday life. Submitted in 2021.
Student: Mr Liang Bingkun. Thesis title: State-Owned Enterprise in Ethiopia. Submitted in 2020.
June 2016 Department of Chinese and Bilingual Studies, Hong Kong Polytechnic University
Field Supervision of 20 undergraduates on pastoralism of Ewenki and Orochen people, two nomadic ethnic minorities in northern China.

CONFERENCES and INVITED TALKS

Organised Conferences

2026 Conference of *China in the World Order*. International Relations Department, Coral Bell School of Asia Pacific Affairs. 13-14 May 2026.
2019 Symposium of *Inter-disciplinary Fieldwork Methods in Africa*. Centre for African Studies, Sun Yat-sen University.
This symposium aims to bring together Chinese anthropologists, linguists and to advance inter-disciplinary methodological tools and promote/formalise ethical review policy among Chinese Africanists.
2018 Symposium of *Articulating China and Africa: Ancient Ties and Contemporary Trends*. Centre for African Studies, Sun Yat-sen University.
Presenters include anthropologists and archaeologists working on African Studies and Sino-Africa relationship.

Selected Invited Talks and Conferences

2024 Invited talk, “Does China’s BRI and Private Investment Abroad Help Industrial Development in the Third World?” held by Australian Centre for China in the World, the Australian National University, 14 March 2024.
2023 “*Breaking Boundaries: Chinese Companies Abroad*” organised by the Australian National University, Australia. 29-30 June 2023.
2023 “*Global China and World Order*” organised by Institute of Ethnology, Academia Sinica, Taipei, Taiwan. 8 June 2023 (online).
2022 Invited talk, “Conflicts of Ethnic Groups behind the Ethiopia Civil War” in *Symposium of Horn of Africa and China’s Overseas Interests* held by Chinese University of Hong Kong on 16 August 2022.
2021 Invited talk, “God, Development, and Technology Transfer: Mediated Ethics between Chinese and Ethiopians” held by Australian Centre for China in the World, the Australian National University, 22 April 2021.
2020 “Remaking Pastoralist Identity: ‘Afar in the Urban Milieu of Gewane, Ethiopia’” to be presented in *5th Oxford Desert Conference* (postponed due to covid-19 outbreak)
2019 “Transforming Solidarity Among the Pastoralist Afar in Ethiopia”, presented in *Interim Conference of International Union of Anthropological and Ethnological Sciences (IUAES)*, Poznan, Poland.
2019 “Reflections on the Borderland Studies of Africa”, *Symposium of Africa’s Local Expertise on Social Sciences and Humanity*. Tsinghua University, Beijing.

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- 2019 “God, Gifts, and Translators: Mediated Ethics between Chinese and Ethiopians”, presented in *International Society for the Study of Chinese Overseas (ISSCO) Conference*, Jinan University, Guangzhou.
- 2018 “A Stretching Road and a Settling Population”, Presented in *OP151 Renovated Infrastructure, Renovated Citizenship of International Union of Anthropological and Ethnological Sciences (IUAES)*, Florianopolis, Brazil.
- 2017 “Ethical Encounter between Chinese and Ethiopians”, presented in *International Symposium on China’s Anthropological Studies of Africa*. Zhejiang Normal University.
- 2016 Invited talk, “Performing Politics, Masculinity, and Citizenship”, presented at Institute of Anthropology at Nanjing University, China.
- 2009 “Labour Control and Cultural Practices: A case study of a family enterprise in Zhejiang Province”, presented at *Symposium of Asian Social Change*, Peking University.

SERVICES

- 2021- I have had the privilege of reviewing manuscripts for esteemed journals such as *Asian Ethnicity*, the *Journal for the Academic Studies of Religion*, the *Sociological Review of China*, and the *Journal of World Peoples Studies (China)*.
- 2022 Sworn English/Chinese Interpreter for the High court of Botswana
- 2021 Provided consultation to the Guangdong provincial government to moderate the harsh epidemiological policy against the African diasporic communities.
- 2020 Fundraising for anti-epidemic materials for two hospitals in waring zone in Ethiopia.
- 2007-9 Director of the Beijing Office of the China-Europa-Forum. Facilitated the formation of 46 workshops between China and Europe and was responsible for Chinese media relations, forum publication, volunteer training and logistics during the biannual conference. The forum is funded by the Charles Léopold Mayer Foundation for the Progress of Humankind (FPH).

LANGUAGES

Native and Native like: Mandarin Chinese and English (Certified Australia NAATI III translator).
Intermediate: Setswana (Botswana).
Beginner: Amharic & ‘Afar (Ethiopia), and French

DIGITAL LITERACY

Teaching platforms (Moodle, Wattle, and Canvas); Statistics (R, SPSS); Microsoft Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Access); Elan (annotation tool).